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Travel Opinion Leaders and Seekers

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Abstract

While opinion leadership has been recognized as important in tourism, there has been very little empirical research investigating the phenomenon. Given new developments in social media technologies, it is especially important to understand whether travel opinion leadership and seeking are drivers of specific social media perceptions and behaviours. Based on an online survey of US online travellers, this paper seeks to identify travel opinion leaders and seekers and their characteristics. Further, the research conducted investigated linkages between travel opinion leadership/seeking and travel social media use. The findings suggest that travel opinion leadership and seeking are distinct but connected. Both opinion leaders and seekers are technology savvy, young, educated, involved in travel planning and engaged in social media use for travel. What distinguishes opinion leaders is their greater travel experience and greater trust in official sources of travel information.

Keywords: opinion leader; opinion seeker; travel; social media; online contents creation.

1 Introduction

Recent developments in social media technologies enable travelers to more easily advocate and share their opinions online. Travelers today can actively create and distribute travel information through the Internet (O'Connor, 2008; Sigala, 2008). Litvin, Goldsmith and Pan (2008) identified studying both originators as well as listeners as central to researching electronic travel word-of-mouth (eWOM) processes. Clearly, not everyone is a travel opinion leader online. Yoo and Gretzel (2008) found that those who passively consume travel e-WOM outnumber by far those who actively contribute and also differ from them in terms of demographics and travel

involvement. Understanding who seeks travel opinions and who is asked for travel advice is crucial in understanding the dynamics of eWOM through social media.

Despite the increasing significance of online opinion leadership and seeking, only limited studies have investigated the role and characteristics of opinion leaders and seekers. Especially in the tourism literature opinion leadership has been mentioned but not extensively researched. An exception is the study by Jamrozy, Backman and Backman (1996) that finds opinion leaders in nature-tourism to be more involved in travel and travel information search. An investigation in the context of travel is necessary as opinion leadership has been identified to be domain-specific (Goldsmith & Flynn, 1993). Given the growing importance of social media activities among travelers, it is vital to understand online opinion leadership from a conceptual point of view. In addition, it is of great practical relevance to know who these travel opinion leaders are and what characteristics their counterparts, the travel opinion seekers, have. Consequently, this study sought to test a scale to measure opinion leadership and seeking in the travel context. Further, it sought to investigate how opinion leaders differ from non-opinion leaders and opinion-seekers from non-seekers and whether opinion leadership and seeking could be connected to social media use.

2 Background

2.1 Social Media in Travel

While various definitions of social media are available (e.g., Safko, 2010), social media are generally understood as a group of Internet-based applications that carry consumer-generated contents such as blogs, social networks, virtual communities, wikis, collaborative tagging, and media files shared on sites like YouTube and Flickr (Xiang & Gretzel, 2009). With the growing importance of social media in travel, many travel industry players are seeking ways to incorporate social media connectivity into their offerings (eMarketer, 2010a). According to a Nielson report (2009), US social network advertising spending for the travel industry jumped 364% from 2008 to 2009 and it is expected to continue to grow since many travel industry practitioners indicate that they plan to expand their Web 2.0 activities (HeBS, 2010).

As increasing numbers of travel providers as well as travellers engage in social media activities, social media have become an important information source for trip planning. According to recent reports by eMarketer (2010b), three out of the top ten online travel information sources used by US adults were social media sites. Further, 23% of US Internet users said their travel and vacation decisions were influenced by social media (eMarketer, 2010a). Clearly, social media are taking on an important role in travellers' information search and decision-making behaviours and provide a fertile

venue for travellers to engage in e-WOM. While traditional WOM is pre-dominantly triggered by receivers who ask for opinions (Mangold, Miller & Brockway, 1999), eWOM through social media is asynchronous, very often unsolicited, and exchanged in many cases with unknown others. Thus, it is important to examine whether opinion leadership actually plays a role in social media.

2.2 Opinion Leadership

Flynn, Goldsmith and Eastman (1996) define opinion leaders as those individuals who influence the purchasing behavior of others in a specific product domain. According to the two-step flow communication model (Lazarsfeld, Berelson, & Gaudet, 1944), an opinion leader is an active media user who interprets the meaning of media messages or content for other media users. Since opinion leaders were found to play an important role in consumer's decision making, the topic of opinion leadership has long been of interest in consumer research. A good number of previous studies have investigated the motives of opinion leadership (Dichter, 1966), measurement (Childers, 1986; Flynn et al., 1996; Tsang & Zhou, 2005) and the outcomes (Bloch, 1986). Previous studies have also identified the characteristics of opinion leaders. Although the findings vary depending on the type of product and context, opinion leaders were often found to be more innovative (Gatignon & Robertson, 1985; Hirschman, 1980), heavy consumers of the mass media (Chan & Misra, 1990; Summers, 1970), socially active (Baumgarten, 1975; Venkatraman, 1989), self-centered (Baumgarten, 1975; Summers, 1970), and to display higher levels of product involvement and familiarity (Allen, 2001; Bloch & Richins, 1983; Goldsmith, Flynn & Goldsmith, 2003; Richins & Root-Shaffer, 1988). In terms of their demographic characteristics, previous studies show that opinion leaders tend to be younger, with a higher level of education and income, and often exhibit greater social mobility (Gatignon & Robertson, 1985; Midgley & Dowling, 1978; Myers & Robertson, 1972; Piirto, 1992). Jamrozy et al. (1996) found that nature-tourism opinion leaders travel more, are more involved in nature-tourism, use more information sources and perceive less risk in making travel-related decisions. Litvin (2000) also found a relationship between frequent travel and opinion leadership.

As Internet technologies enable interpersonal communication online, some recent studies have examined opinion leadership in the online context. Lyons and Henderson (2005) found that the characteristics of online opinion leaders are similar to the characteristics of opinion leaders in an offline setting. Their findings show that online opinion leaders possess significantly higher levels of enduring involvement, innovativeness, exploratory behavior and self-perceived knowledge than non-leaders. In addition, online opinion leaders possess greater computer skills and have used the Internet for longer periods of time and more frequently. Sohn (2005) also found

consistent patterns of opinion leadership and seeking behaviors across online and offline environments.

2.3 Opinion Seeking

Opinion seekers were defined by existing literature as "individuals who sought information or opinions from interpersonal sources in order to find out about and evaluate products, services, current affairs, or other areas of interest" (Feick, Price & Higie, 1986, p. 302). The topic of opinion seeking has received less research attention and researchers often see opinion seeking as a co-phenomenon of opinion leadership (Flynn et al., 1996; Shoham & Ruvio, 2008). From the perspective of the two-step flow communication theory (Lazarsfeld, Berelson, & Gaudet, 1944), opinion seekers are viewed as the message receivers who get the information through opinion leaders. Beatty and Smith (1987) suggested that a person who has little knowledge or who is worried about a purchase is highly likely to seek advice from someone they know. Similarly, Alba and Hutchinson (1987) found that younger, less-experienced consumers rely more heavily on the expertise of others. Opinion seekers also tend to regard word-of-mouth recommendations from friends and relatives as more credible than information from commercial sources (Assael, 1992).

As far as the relationship between opinion leading and seeking is concerned, Piirto (1992) suggested that opinion leaders and seekers can be differentiated by the level of their activities in a social network. Flynn et al. (1996) discussed that these two concepts are related and that there may be some overlap between them but noted that they are nevertheless two distinct constructs. In contrast, the findings of Feick et al. (1986) suggested that there is a high overlap between opinion giving and seeking and the profile of opinion seekers is similar to the profile of opinion leaders.

3 Methodology

3.1 Data Collection

An online survey was conducted in January 2010 to investigate whether online travellers could successfully be classified into opinion leaders and seekers, and whether they fundamentally differed in terms of personal characteristics, travel behaviour, and social media engagement. The survey was sent to members of a commercial online research panel residing in the United States. No additional incentives beyond the rewards provided by the panel company were offered. A total of 2,046 panellists responded to the survey invitation but only 1,810 indicated they were active Internet users. Further, of those Internet users, 1,221 had travelled for

pleasure within 12 months prior to the study. These online travellers form the actual sample for the study.

3.2 Measures

Opinion leadership and seeking were measured based on two scales adapted from Flynn et al. (1996), who conceptualized them as people's perceptions of their own influence over others vs. others' influence on them. Both constructs were measured with four positively worded items that had been adjusted to fit the travel context. Respondents were asked to indicate their agreement/disagreement with the items on a 5point scale ranging from Strongly Disagree (1) to Strongly Agree (5). The survey also included measures gauging socio-demographic characteristics, travel behaviour, Internet use and skills, and social media perceptions and engagement in general and in the context of travel. Innovativeness was measured with three items on a 5point scale adapted from Goldsmith and Hofacker (1991).

Table 1. Properties of Measurement Scales

Construct Name & Items	Mean	Factor Loadings	Eigen Value	% of Variance	α
Opinion Leading	3.03		3.362	42.0	.94
When they choose travel, other people turn to me for advice.	2.96	.890			
People that I know pick travel products based on what I have told them.	2.98	.890			
My opinion on travel seems to count with other people.	3.15	.880			
I often influence people's opinions about travel.	3.03	.878			
Opinion Seeking	3.18		3.318	41.5	.93
I like to get others' opinions before I buy travel products.	3.19	.908			
I feel more comfortable buying travel when I have gotten other people's opinion on it.	3.18	.899			
When choosing travel products, other people's opinions are important to me.	3.17	.864			
When I consider buying travel products, I ask other people for advice	3.19	.837			

3.3 Analysis

An exploratory factor analysis with principal components extraction and Varimax rotation showed that the opinion leading and opinion seeking constructs were indeed

distinct (Table 1). The KMO score was high (.883) and Bartlett's test of sphericity was significant ($p < .001$), also suggesting that factor analysis is appropriate. The individual items loaded strongly onto the respective factors, which cumulatively accounted for 83.5% of the variance explained. Reliability tests also showed high internal consistency of the factors with Cronbach Alpha scores over .90. Therefore, two separate additive scales were constructed. The innovativeness scale also showed excellent properties with factor loadings above .92, a variance explained of 86.6% and a Cronbach Alpha score of .92. Respondents were then classified as opinion seekers and leaders based on their score for the two scales, with 3.1 serving as the cut-off point. Crosstabulation was used to examine potential overlaps of opinion leaders and seekers. Crosstabulation and t-tests were used to test for differences in opinion leaders and non-leaders as well as in seekers and non-seekers.

4 Results

4.1 Profile of Sample

The respondents were on average 45.3 years old and mostly Caucasian (81.3%). The sample included slightly more males (53.7%) than females (46.3%). Almost half (49.0%) were married, 27% single, 14.5% divorced/separated/widowed, 9% living with a partner and 0.5% did not wish to comment. In terms of employment, 40.3% indicated they were fully employed and 18.4% were retired. Many had a college or postgraduate degree (43.1%); however, most (87.9%) had household incomes of less than \$100,000. About half (53.4%) of the respondents had taken one or two trips, 25.8% had taken 3-4 trips and the rest had taken 5 or more trips in 2009. Many (40.6%) considered themselves to be advanced Internet users or at least intermediate users (35.4%). The majority (55.7%) did not see itself as particularly innovative. Over half (50.9%) indicated they generally trusted comments/materials posted by other travellers online, yet only 44.2% said they typically looked at information posted online by other travellers when planning an overnight pleasure trip. A mere 21.9% stated they had actively posted travel-related comments/materials online.

4.2 Opinion Leaders vs. Seekers

The results of the classification of respondents into opinion leaders and opinion seekers showed that 45.2% perceived themselves to be opinion leaders while a greater percentage (53.2%) thought they were opinion seekers. Flynn et al. (1996) suggest that while opinion leaders are typically also opinion seekers, not all opinion seekers are also opinion leaders. The crosstab analysis was significant ($p = .000$) and indicated that 76.8% of the opinion leaders were also opinion seekers, while only 65.2% of the opinion seekers saw themselves also as opinion leaders. Nevertheless,

this suggests quite substantial overlap in accordance with Feick et al. (1986). Over a third of the respondents (36.3%) were neither opinion seekers nor opinion leaders and 34.7% indicated they were both. Only 10.5% of the respondents saw themselves as opinion leaders but not opinion seekers and 18.5% identified themselves as pure opinion seekers (Table 2).

Table 2. Overlap between Opinion Leadership and Seeking

Opinion Leading	Opinion Seeking	
	No	Yes
No	36.3%	18.5%
Yes	10.5%	34.7%

Demographic differences. No gender differences were found between travel opinion leaders and non-leaders. However, travel opinion seekers are more likely ($p=.034$) male (56.8%) than female (43.2%). This suggests that females experience greater self-efficacy when planning travel and, thus, are less likely to ask others for advice in the context of their travel planning. To look at age differences, the respondents were divided into generational cohorts. Opinion leaders are less likely ($p<.01$) members of the Silent Generation (12.4% vs. 18.6%) and the Baby Boomer Generation (28.9% vs. 33.6%) and are more likely to be Gen Xers (37.7% vs. 30.0%) and Millennials (21.0% vs. 17.8%). The same trend was found for opinion seekers. No significant relationship was found between opinion leadership and marital status, while the results suggest that opinion seekers are somewhat less likely divorced/separated/widowed (11.4% vs. 18.0%; $p=.048$). Both opinion seekers and opinion leaders are more likely to be fully employed and are less likely to be retired or unemployed. Also, both are more likely to have university degrees (opinion seekers 47.5% vs. 38.0%; opinion leaders 36.7% vs. 50.8%). No significant differences were found for ethnic origin. As far as income is concerned, opinion seekers do not significantly differ from non-seekers. In contrast, opinion leaders have higher household incomes than non-opinion leaders (29.0% vs. 18.9% have incomes over \$75,000). These results confirm previous findings from the general consumer literature in terms of opinion leaders being more likely young and educated.

Travel characteristics. Opinion leaders travel significantly more than non-opinion leaders, with 56.7% compared to 39.6% indicating that they had gone on more than two trips in 2009. No significant differences were found for opinion seeking and travel frequency. Opinion leaders are also more likely to have taken an international trip as their most recent trip (9.6% vs. 5.6%; $p=.02$) while no such difference was found for opinion seekers. Opinion leaders are less likely to indicate that they had no active role in planning their most recent trip (4.5% compared to 8.5%; $p=.01$). The

same trend can be found for opinion seekers but the difference is much smaller (5.3% vs. 8.2%; $p=.05$).

Technology affinity. Opinion leaders are significantly ($p<.01$) more innovative when it comes to technology (mean=3.44 compared to 2.73 for non-opinion leaders). The difference also exists for opinion seekers but is a lot smaller (mean opinion seekers=3.24 compared to 2.84 for non-opinion seekers; $p<.01$). Opinion leaders are more likely to indicate that they are advanced Internet users compared to non-opinion leaders (47.1% vs. 35.2%). Differences are especially apparent for the expert level, into which 24.3% of opinion leaders classified themselves compared to only 9.9% of non-opinion leaders. Seekers also see themselves more as advanced users (46.6% vs. 33.8%) and expert users (19.7% vs. 12.6%). Opinion seekers are also more likely to have used the Internet for planning their most recent overnight pleasure trip (85.7% compared to 68.8%; $p<.01$). The same is true for seekers (82.0% vs. 70.1%).

4.3 Opinion Leadership and Seeking and Social Travel Media

Opinion leaders are a lot more likely to indicate that they typically look at/read comments or materials posted online by other travellers in the course of planning their overnight pleasure trips (58.0% vs. 32.9%; $p<.01$), as are opinion seekers (56.7% vs. 30.1%). Both opinion leaders and opinion seekers see media generated by other travellers as more important for travel planning than non-leaders and non-seekers (Table 3). Both groups place the greatest value on travel reviews and ratings by other travellers.

Table 3. Mean Differences in Perceived Importance of Specific Types of Consumer-Generated Media (CGM) for Travel Planning

Type of CGM	Leaders	Non-Leaders	Seekers	Non-Seekers
Travel reviews and ratings	3.75	3.37	3.73	3.31
Tweets	2.36	1.91	2.30	1.91
Photos posted by travellers	3.35	2.84	3.29	2.82
Videos posted by travellers	3.02	2.53	2.98	2.48
Blogs by other travellers	2.99	2.60	3.01	2.45
Postings in virtual communities	3.13	2.67	3.16	2.49
Audio files/podcasts	2.54	2.20	2.53	2.14
Postings on Facebook	2.68	2.28	2.64	2.26

Values reported are means on a 5pt scale ranging from Not at all Important to Essential; $p<.01$

As far as trust is concerned, both opinion leaders and opinion seekers trust media generated by other travellers more than non-leaders and non-seekers (Table 4). However, interestingly, opinion leaders do not trust CGM more than

editorial/marketer information contained in official reviews, travel articles, guidebooks, etc. while opinion seekers do. When it comes to actively contributing contents, both opinion leaders and seekers are more likely to have engaged in posting than non-opinion leaders (31.6% compared to 13.9%) and non-seekers (28.8% vs. 14.0%). Interesting differences also exist for Twitter and Facebook use, with both opinion leaders and opinion seekers being more likely to use these social media in the context of travel (Table 5).

Table 4. Mean Differences in Trust in CGM

Type of CGM	Leaders	Non-Leaders	Seekers	Non-Seekers
In general, I trust comments/materials posted by other travellers.	3.63	3.22	3.67	3.11
I feel confident that the comments/materials provided by other travellers are posted with the best intentions in mind.	3.78	3.39	3.81	3.29
The comments/materials posted by other travellers are a reliable source of travel information.	3.62	3.17	3.64	3.07
I trust reviews, ratings, and comments by other travellers more than evaluations provided in formal travel reviews, articles, etc.	n.s.	n.s.	3.27	2.96

Values reported are means on a 5pt scale ranging from Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree; $p < .01$

Table 5. Percentage of Social Media Users

Social Media Use	Leaders	Non-Leaders	Seekers	Non-Seekers
Follow a travel company on Twitter.	9.6	1.9	8.7	1.6
Downloaded travel-related app.	17.9	5.1	15.2	6.0
Have personal Facebook profile.	63.8	54.9	62.9	54.4
Fan of a travel company on Facebook.	36.1	19.2	33.4	19.7
Member of a travel group on Facebook.	28.4	9.0	26.5	8.0

5 Conclusions

From a theoretical point of view, the research contributed to the literature on opinion leadership in travel as well as the general literature on opinion leadership in terms of updating its relevance for the social media context. It also introduced opinion seeking as a relevant domain to be studied in the context of tourism. The findings show that

travel opinion leadership and opinion seeking are two distinct domains that are highly connected, with many travel opinion leaders also being opinion seekers. This supports previous findings, which suggest the two domains are positively related (Feick et al., 1986). Some past research has argued that product involvement actually matters in the context of opinion leadership (Girardi, Soutar & Ward, 2005; Shoham & Ruvio, 2008); therefore, the study made an important contribution by examining the concepts in a high involvement context such as travel. Our findings also suggest that both opinion leaders and seekers have distinct demographic characteristics. Opinion leaders are involved in travel planning, and are more savvy and innovative technology users. Travel opinion leaders are also more frequent and international travellers, while this is not a characteristic that distinguishes seekers from non-seekers. Most importantly, both opinion leaders and seekers are heavy users of and contributors to social media for travel and trust these new information sources more than non-leaders or non-seekers. However, opinion leaders do not trust social media more than official sources while opinion seekers do. Opinion leaders probably consider themselves to be experts and will likely think they possess the knowledge that the general travellers communicate through social media. What they are looking for is insider knowledge that is provided by the industry so that they can communicate it to others. In that respect, the current study shows that the two-step communication flow model (Lazarsfeld et al., 1944) is still relevant in the social media era.

From a practical point of view, the findings suggest that travel marketers need to target those who are opinion leaders and need to make it easy for them to share information. At the same time, mechanisms could be developed to recognize opinion leaders. Virtual communities already do that to some extent by awarding influential members with rankings or trophies visible to other users. From a research point of view, now that the scales have been established, they should be further tested regarding their generalizability across cultures and their relationship with other concepts such as personality, specific travel planning behaviours, as well as travel preferences.

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